Daily Content Intel

July 2, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, here's something that should change how you run practice. A brand new systematic review pooled 15 studies and almost 500 youth team-sport athletes, comparing small-sided games against the old-school running conditioning we all grew up with.

Small-sided games are what they sound like. You shrink the field, you drop the numbers, 3 on 3, 4 on 4, and you keep the game going.

The games improved maximal aerobic capacity, high-intensity endurance, acceleration, change of direction, and lower-body power. That's basically every physical quality that shows up on a field, from one kind of drill.

Here's what I care about as a clinician. The kids playing games reported lower psychological stress than the kids running lines. You build a more durable, better-conditioned athlete, and they actually want to be there.

The one thing games didn't move much was top-end sprint speed. That still needs real sprinting. So the Monday takeaway is simple. Keep your speed work, and replace most of your straight-line conditioning with small-area games.

You condition the engine and sharpen the change-of-direction that football and lacrosse actually demand, at the same time.

Does that make sense?

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: You can build a fitter, faster athlete without a single gasser.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, here's something that should change how you run practice. A brand new systematic review pooled 15 studies and almost 500 youth team-sport athletes, comparing small-sided games against the old-school running conditioning we all grew up with.

Small-sided games are what they sound like. You shrink the field, you drop the numbers, 3 on 3, 4 on 4, and you keep the game going.

The games improved maximal aerobic capacity, high-intensity endurance, acceleration, change of direction, and lower-body power. That's basically every physical quality that shows up on a field, from one kind of drill.

Here's what I care about as a clinician. The kids playing games reported lower psychological stress than the kids running lines. You build a more durable, better-conditioned athlete, and they actually want to be there.

The one thing games didn't move much was top-end sprint speed. That still needs real sprinting. So the Monday takeaway is simple. Keep your speed work, and replace most of your straight-line conditioning with small-area games.

You condition the engine and sharpen the change-of-direction that football and lacrosse actually demand, at the same time.

Does that make sense?

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 Fitter AND faster. Zero gassers.
- 0:06 New review: 15 studies, ~500 youth athletes
- 0:14 Small-sided games = shrink field, drop numbers
- 0:26 Up: aerobic capacity, endurance, acceleration, COD, power
- 0:40 Lower mental stress than running lines
- 0:52 Didn't move top-end sprint speed

- 0:58 Keep speed work + swap conditioning for small games

Caption (copy-paste ready):

New systematic review, 15 studies, almost 500 youth team-sport athletes: small-sided games improved maximal aerobic capacity, high-intensity endurance, acceleration, change of direction, and lower-body power. The kids playing games also reported less psychological stress than the ones running lines.

The one quality games didn't move was top-end sprint speed. That still needs dedicated sprinting.

So if you coach football or lacrosse: keep your speed work, and turn most of your conditioning into small-area games. You build the engine and the change-of-direction the sport actually demands, and the athletes want to be there.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT It's time to cross your threshold.
threshold.clientsecure.me

#footballtraining #lacrossetraining #youthsports #strengthandconditioning #speedtraining #athleticdevelopment #sportsperformance #hsfootball #lacrosse #coaching

Personalize this

- When you program conditioning for your HS football guys, how much is still straight-line running versus small-area or 7-on-7 style games, and what's the first thing you'd swap out?
- Have you seen the buy-in difference on the field, guys who dog it through gassers but compete hard in a 3-on-3? Got a quick story?
- For your club-lacrosse athletes, which small-area game do you use to get change-of-direction under fatigue, and how do you keep it from turning into junk conditioning?

Screenshots:

- title | https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1803471/full | "Effects of small-sided games training on physical performance in youth team-sport athletes: a systematic review and meta-analysis"

- physiology | https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1803471/full | "SSG significantly improved maximal aerobic capacity (SMD = 0.78, 95% CI: 0.30 to 1.27, p = 0.001), intermittent high-intensity endurance (SMD = 1.05, 95% CI: 0.70 to 1.40, p< 0.001), sprint acceleration (SMD = –0.55, 95% CI: –1.02 to –0.09, p = 0.019), change-of-direction ability (SMD = –0.85, 95% CI: –1.38 to –0.33, p = 0.001), and lower-limb explosive power (SMD = 0.60, 95% CI: 0.25 to 0.96, p = 0.001)"
- actionable | https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1803471/full | "SSG training can be integrated into physical conditioning programs for youth team-sport athletes, supporting the development of multiple match-related physical performance capacities."

Sources:

- https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1803471/full

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, hot take. The idea that creatine will wreck your high schooler's kidneys is one of the most stubborn myths I deal with, and a new 2026 systematic review just took it apart.

They pulled the human studies on creatine monohydrate in adolescents and active kids, and across all of them they found no consistent safety signals in kidney function, liver enzymes, or heart and metabolic markers. No serious adverse events tied to the supplement. One study even followed kids for about 7 years and saw no cardiometabolic harm.

Let me be fair, because this matters. It's a small number of studies, most were short, and some of the groups weren't healthy athletes. So keep the dose sensible. What the data keeps showing is that the kidney scare, the thing everyone repeats, doesn't actually show up.

Here's how I think about it. Creatine is one of the most studied supplements we have, it's cheap, and it helps with strength, power, and recovery. The real-world athlete study used a short loading phase around 20 grams for a week, then 5 grams a day, and kidney and liver markers stayed clean all season.

If your kid trains hard and eats well, creatine monohydrate is a reasonable, well-tolerated option. Buy a third-party tested brand, and keep the dose sane.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Creatine is not going to wreck your teenager's kidneys.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, hot take. The idea that creatine will wreck your high schooler's kidneys is one of the most stubborn myths I deal with, and a new 2026 systematic review just took it apart.

They pulled the human studies on creatine monohydrate in adolescents and active kids, and across all of them they found no consistent safety signals in kidney function, liver enzymes, or heart and metabolic markers. No serious adverse events tied to the supplement. One study even followed kids for about 7 years and saw no cardiometabolic harm.

Let me be fair, because this matters. It's a small number of studies, most were short, and some of the groups weren't healthy athletes. So keep the dose sensible. What the data keeps showing is that the kidney scare, the thing everyone repeats, doesn't actually show up.

Here's how I think about it. Creatine is one of the most studied supplements we have, it's cheap, and it helps with strength, power, and recovery. The real-world athlete study used a short loading phase around 20 grams for a week, then 5 grams a day, and kidney and liver markers stayed clean all season.

If your kid trains hard and eats well, creatine monohydrate is a reasonable, well-tolerated option. Buy a third-party tested brand, and keep the dose sane.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 "Creatine won't wreck your teen's kidneys."
- 0:07 2026 systematic review: creatine in adolescents
- 0:17 No consistent signals: kidney, liver, cardiometabolic
- 0:25 0 serious adverse events tied to creatine
- 0:32 7-yr follow-up: no cardiometabolic harm
- 0:42 Small # of studies, mostly short: stay sensible
- 0:54 Dose: ~20g/day x 1 wk, then 5g/day
- 1:02 3rd-party tested brand, sane dose

Caption (copy-paste ready):

The most stubborn myth I deal with as a PT: "creatine will hurt my kid's kidneys." A 2026 systematic review of the human studies in adolescents and active youth found no consistent safety signals in kidney function, liver enzymes, or cardiometabolic markers, and no serious adverse events tied to creatine. One cohort followed kids about 7 years with no cardiometabolic harm.

Fair caveats: small number of studies, most short, some groups weren't healthy athletes. So keep the dose sensible.

Creatine monohydrate is one of the most studied supplements we have, it's cheap, and it supports strength, power, and recovery. Real-world athlete dosing: about 20g/day for a week, then 5g/day, with kidney and liver markers clean across a season. Buy a third-party tested brand.

Not medical advice. Talk to your kid's provider.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT It's time to cross your threshold.

threshold.clientsecure.me

#creatine #sportsnutrition #youthsports #hsfootball #lacrosse #strengthandconditioning #athletictraining #sportsmedicine #creatinemonohydrate #teenathletes

Personalize this

- Which of your HS football or lacrosse athletes are already asking about creatine, and how do you currently answer the parent who's scared of it?
- Do you have a go-to third-party tested creatine brand and a dosing protocol you give athletes, and would you run a loading phase or just start at 5 grams?
- Any athlete of yours who added creatine and you saw a real jump in their weight-room numbers or recovery between sessions? Worth telling as a story.

Screenshots:

- title | https://www.cureus.com/articles/471288-evaluating-the-safety-of-creatine-monohydrate-in-adolescents-a-systematic-revi ew-of-renal-hepatic-and-cardiometabolic-outcomes | "Evaluating the Safety of Creatine Monohydrate in Adolescents: A Systematic Review of Renal, Hepatic, and Cardiometabolic Outcomes"

- physiology | https://www.cureus.com/articles/471288-evaluating-the-safety-of-creatine-monohydrate-in-adolescents-a-systematic-review-of-renal-hepatic-and-cardiometabolic-outcomes | "creatine supplementation was generally well tolerated, with no consistent short-term safety signals reported in renal function, liver enzymes, or cardiometabolic risk markers within the study periods"
- actionable | https://www.cureus.com/articles/471288-evaluating-the-safety-of-creatine-monohydrate-in-adolescents-a-systematic-review-of-renal-hepatic-and-cardiometabolic-outcomes | "Several trials employed loading-maintenance strategies consisting of short loading phases (e.g., 20 g/day) followed by maintenance dosing (e.g., 5 g/day)"

Sources:

- https://www.cureus.com/articles/471288-evaluating-the-safety-of-creatine-monohydrate-in-adolescents-a-systematic-review-of-renal-hepatic-and-cardiometabolic-outcomes

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Single-dose creatine reduces sleep-deprivation-induced cognitive decline (MDPI Nutrients 2025) — research reel on protecting reaction time and decision-making on tournament-weekend / exam-week sleep debt.
- Small-sided games vs running-based HIIT for repeated-sprint ability (PMC meta) — pairs with today's Draft A if it performs.
- Velocity-based training device reliability review — equipment-overrated hot take ("you don't need a $500 bar tracker to train speed").

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest (2026-07-02): only 1 source, a Dr. Mercola promo email ("The First Signs May Not Start in the Brain," gut-brain axis + supplement ads). No athlete-actionable, non-promo finding. Skipped.

- PubMed / Frontiers / MDPI (last 7 days, athlete-biased): surfaced a fresh 2026 systematic review on small-sided games vs running conditioning in youth team-sport athletes (used for Draft A), plus a fresh April 2026 Cureus systematic review on creatine safety in adolescents (used for Draft B). Also surfaced single-dose creatine + sleep-deprivation cognition (MDPI Nutrients, runner-up) and small-sided games vs running HIIT repeated-sprint ability (PMC meta, runner-up).
- ACL/hamstring prevention search returned mostly 2024-2025 material already well-covered in the registry (Nordic, plyometrics) — skipped to avoid dedup hits.
- NSCA VBT / recovery search returned evergreen VBT reviews, nothing newsworthy in the last 7 days; velocity-device reliability review noted as a future hot-take runner-up.
- Dedup check: both chosen primary URLs are absent from cited-sources.json (56 entries). Registry recently covered

resisted sprint (07-01), agility (07-01), early specialization (06-30), detraining (06-30), so those lanes were avoided.